There was some aspirational chatter about putting the Palestinian Authority in charge of Gaza, though no one could articulate how this was meant to happen, short of strapping Abbas onto a Merkava tank and driving him across the border. “Like asking a priest to convert to Judaism,” quipped Amos Yadlin, a former head of military intelligence.

While most Israelis supported the war, only a small minority—between 8 and 30 per cent across three polls in July—thought it would actually bring long-term quiet (like the 2006 Lebanon war, which ended with more than a decade of calm on the northern border). Yet there was no criticism from the left. Isaac Herzog, the Labor leader and the ostensible head of the opposition, acted as Netanyahu’s unofficial spokesman. He convened dozens of foreign diplomats on 1 August—including the ambassadors from France, Germany and other European countries—to defend Israel’s conduct in Gaza. A senior Brazilian diplomat asked him about a pair of Norwegian doctors who had traveled to Gaza to treat casualties; Israel had barred one of them from entering. “The world has remained silent about the massacres in Syria,” Herzog replied, “and with all due respect to the important work of the Norwegian doctors, are these doctors aware of the missiles stored under the hospital?” Tal Schneider, an Israeli journalist who attended the briefing, said his remarks were “straight from Netanyahu’s talking points.”[31]

Instead the criticism came from the right. Before the war even started, Danny Danon, the deputy defense minister, urged the government to “shut off the electricity” in the West Bank and Gaza, to punish Palestinians for the kidnappings and the steadily increasing rocket fire. A few weeks later he called the Egyptian ceasefire proposal “humiliating”. Netanyahu eventually fired him for insubordination.

Danon had long been a thorn in Netanyahu’s side. He also served as the chairman of Likud’s central committee, and helped to steer the party further to the right, effectively turning Netanyahu into the most liberal member of his own faction. This was an ironic turnabout, as Netanyahu had used the same tactics against Ariel Sharon a decade earlier. “My position is to make sure we’re not becoming a construct of the left,” Danon told me that summer. “As long as [Netanyahu] stays loyal, he’ll have the backing of the party.”

He didn’t enjoy much backing from other parties, either. Naftali Bennett, the head of the right-wing Jewish Home, said Israel should “strike at Hamas mercilessly” until the group was disarmed or destroyed. Foreign Minister